

Document 1: Common Cold (Viral Upper Respiratory Infection)

Metadata

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Definition of Common Cold

The common cold is a mild, self-limiting viral infection of the upper respiratory tract (nose and throat). Rhinoviruses are the most frequent cause of the common cold.

Symptoms of Common Cold

Symptoms of a common cold typically appear 1 to 3 days after exposure to the virus and peak within 2 to 3 days. Common symptoms include:

- Nasal congestion or runny nose (rhinorrhea)
- Scratchy or sore throat (pharyngitis)
- Sneezing and mild cough
- Low-grade fever (more common in children than adults)
- Mild fatigue and body aches

Treatment and Management for Common Cold

There is no cure for the common cold; treatment focuses on symptom relief. Standard management includes:

- **Hydration:** Drinking plenty of water and clear fluids to thin mucus.
- **Rest:** Adequate sleep supports immune system function.
- **Medications:** Over-the-counter (OTC) pain relievers (acetaminophen or ibuprofen) for body aches, and saline nasal drops or OTC decongestants for nasal congestion.
- **Note:** Antibiotics do not treat viral infections like the common cold and should not be used.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Common Cold

A patient should consult a healthcare provider regarding a cold if they experience:

- Symptoms lasting longer than 10 to 14 days without improvement.
- Fever greater than 101.3°F (38.5°C) lasting more than 3 days.
- Shortness of breath, wheezing, or severe chest pain.
- Severe sinus pain or earache.